

In the Shadow of Bezalel.
Aramaic, Biblical, and Ancient
Near Eastern Studies in Honor
of Bezalel Porten

Edited by
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CONTENTS

Preface	ix
“Mr. Elephantine” Bezalel Porten	xi
Bezalel Porten Curriculum Vitae	xvii
List of Contributors	xxxv
Tabula Gratulatoria—For Buzzy ועד מאה ועשרים כעשרים! ...	xxxvii
Abba	xliii
Abbreviations	vi

ARAMAIC STUDIES / ELEPHANTINE

Women of Elephantine and Women in the Land of Israel <i>Annalisa Azzoni</i>	3
Der Wandel des Aramäischen veranschaulicht durch Transkriptionen alter aramäischer Texte <i>Klaus Beyer</i>	13
Three Additional Aramaic-Egyptian Parallel Legal Terms/Formulae <i>Alejandro F. Botta</i>	29
The Career of Some Elephantine and Murašû Scribes and Witnesses <i>Eleonora Cussini</i>	39
Phoenician and Aramaic Inscriptions from Abusir <i>Jan Dušek and Jana Mynářová</i>	53
On רכש, <i>rakkasu</i> , and <i>raksu</i> <i>Frederick Mario Fales</i>	71
Rare Demonstrative Pronouns in Targum Onqelos: דיכי and דנן <i>Margaretha Folmer</i>	89

Elephantine and the Torah	125
<i>Lester L. Grabbe</i>	
Gleanings from the Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon II: Notes on the State of Modern Syriac Lexicography	137
<i>Stephen A. Kaufman</i>	
Le Dialecte Araméen de L'inscription De Kuttamuwa (Zencirli, Viie S. Av. N. È.)	145
<i>André Lemaire</i>	
Clermont-Ganneau 253: Une revisite et un reclassement obligés	151
<i>Hélène Lozachmeur</i>	
Epistolographische Elemente in den neuveröffentlichten aramäischen Ostrakonbriefen aus Elephantine (Sammlung Clermont-Ganneau)	159
<i>Dirk Schwiderski</i>	
Le phénomène de mutation des interdentes en araméen, <i>ou</i> la Quête de «la langue parfaite». De la réforme orthographique à l'époque perse à la <i>différenciation maxima</i> ...	183
<i>Ursula Schattner-Rieser</i>	
Die „Festung“ von Elephantine in der Spätzeit – Anmerkungen zum archäologischen Befund	203
<i>Cornelius von Pilgrim</i>	
Twelve Published and Unpublished Jewish Aramaic Ostraca Written in the “Jewish” Cursive Script	209
<i>Ada Yardeni</i>	

BIBLICAL STUDIES

Metaphor in the Book of Psalms or the Book of Psalms as Metaphor?	247
<i>Stephen A. Geller</i>	

Revisiting the Date of King Josiah's Death	255
<i>Dan'el Kahn</i>	
"Wisdom is of the Gods" An Aramaic Antecedent to Proverbs 8 (Or: "The Case of the Vanishing Evidence!")	265
<i>James M. Lindenberger</i>	
Does the Enigmatic Phrase שְׁבָעוֹת מִטּוֹת אֱמֶר (Hab 3:9) Represent Liturgical Glosses?	277
<i>David Marcus</i>	
Philological Notes on the David-Bathsheba Story I	289
<i>Takamitsu Muraoka</i>	
The First Born/Eldest Son of Death/The Underworld, Job 18:13	305
<i>Shalom M. Paul</i>	
A Poem within a Poem: Some Literary Aspects of the Lament for Saul and Jonathan	309
<i>Jan-Wim Wesseliüs</i>	

ANCIENT NEAR EASTERN STUDIES

The Role of the Governor in Persian Imperial Administration	319
<i>Lisbeth S. Fried</i>	
Emar and the Elephantine Papyri	333
<i>Andrew D. Gross</i>	
Setting Another Tablet Right: The Ugaritic Text RS 2.[031]	351
<i>Dennis Pardee</i>	
Ad Nomen Argumenta: Personal Names as Pejorative Puns in Ancient Texts	367
<i>Christopher A. Rollston</i>	

The Archive of Šamaš-Šarra-Ušur from Calah	387
<i>Ran Zadok</i>	
Der Ägyptische Name der Juden	409
<i>Karl-Theodor Zauzich</i>	
Index	417

PHOENICIAN AND ARAMAIC INSCRIPTIONS FROM ABUSIR¹

Jan Dušek and Jana Mynářová

1. Introduction

Since the Old Kingdom, the site of Abusir constituted an integral part of a long aggregation of cemeteries, stretching along the west bank of the Nile River and belonging to the capital city of Memphis. Through the centuries and millennia, the importance of the city itself varied, reaching its last pinnacle during the Twenty-Sixth Dynasty (ca. 664–525 BCE), when Memphis once again became an administrative centre of the country.

A considerable increase in the usage of the city's necropolae occurred during same period of time, first of all at Saqqara, but neither the site of Abusir stood apart. Memphis of this period was generally understood as a multicultural *metropolis* of the ancient world. As in the New Kingdom, an indispensable portion of the city represented “foreigners”² during this particular period of time, including Phoenicians of Tyre (also mentioned by Herodotus, in *The Histories* II, 112),³ Aramaic speakers,⁴ and Carians,⁵ among others.

¹ This study is the result of a research activity that is part of the grant project GAČR 404/09/0162 “Centre or Periphery?—History and Culture of Syropalestine (3000–300 BCE).” We would like to express our thanks to Miroslav Verner and Ladislav Bareš for allowing us to study and publish the Abusir material, and to Květa Smoláriková for her suggestions and comments. We are especially grateful to André Lemaire, who read some of these inscriptions before us and who shared with us his preliminary observations.

² Günter Vittmann, *Ägypten und die Fremden im ersten Vorchristlichen Jahrtausend*, Kulturgeschichte der Antiken Welt (Mainz: von Zabern, 2003), 97.

³ Concerning Phoenicians and Egypt, see Jean Leclant, “Les Phéniciens et l’Égypte,” in *Atti del II Congresso Internazionale di Studi Fenici e Punici, Roma 9–14 Novembre 1987, Volume Primo*, Collezione di Studi Fenici 30, ed. Enrico Acquaro et al. (Roma: Consiglio Nazionale delle Ricerche, 1991), 7–17.

⁴ For the Aramaic labels and Achaemenid seal impressions discovered at the Memphite Palace of Apries, see William M. F. Petrie, Ernest Mackay and Gerald Wainwright, *Meydum and Memphis (III)*, British School of Archaeology in Egypt and Egyptian Research Account, Sixteenth Year (London: School of Archaeology in Egypt—Bernard Quaritch, 1910), 40–42, pls. XXXIV–XXXVI.

⁵ Consult, especially in general, Karl-Theodor Zauzich, *Einige karische Inschriften aus Ägypten und Kleinasien und ihre Deutung nach der Entzifferung der karischen*

The period at the end of the Twenty-Sixth Dynasty determined the last swing of prosperity for Abusir, when an entirely new cemetery was founded on a small hill in the westernmost part of the site.⁶ Though the new site was established relatively far from the Nile valley, it had access both to the valley itself and to North Saqqara. Consisting of a series of large and small shaft-tombs, organized in double rows and running roughly from west to east, the site was established during a short period of time at the very end of the Twenty-Sixth Dynasty.⁷ The primacy of the site rapidly and suddenly terminated during the unstable period following the Kambyes' invasion to Egypt in 525 BCE.

However, it stands to reason that next to the large shaft tombs belonging to members of higher echelons of Egyptian society,⁸ the site was also largely used as a burial place for a number of ordinary Egyptians. Evidence of their burials can be found throughout the necropolis, including the vicinity of royal complexes of the Fifth Dynasty further to the north. These pit burials, provided with merely the poorest of

Schrift (Wiesbaden: Harrassowitz, 1972); Michael Meier-Brügger, "Ein Buchstabenindex zu den karischen Schriftdenkmälern aus Ägypten," *Kadmos* 18 (1979): 130–77; Frank Kammerzell, *Studien zu Sprache und Geschichte der Karer in Ägypten*, Göttinger Orientforschungen. IV. Reihe: Ägypten, 27 (Wiesbaden: Harrassowitz, 1993); for the Memphite area, see Olivier Masson and Jean Yoyotte, *Objets Pharaoniques à Inscription Carienne*, Bibliothèque d'Étude, XV (Le Caire: Imprimerie de l'Institut Français d'Archéologie Orientale, 1956); Olivier Masson, *Carian Inscriptions from North Saqqâra and Buhen, Texts from Excavations*, Fifth Memoir, Excavations at North Saqqâra. Documentary Series 3 (London: Egypt Exploration Society, 1978); Ignacio J. Adiego, *The Carian Language*, HdO 86 (Leiden: Brill, 2007), 34–79.

⁶ See recently, with references and further literature, Ladislav Bareš, "The Necropolis at Abusir in the First Millennium BC," in *Studies in Honour of Ali Radwan*, Suppléments aux Annales du Service des Antiquités de l'Égypte 34, ed. Khaled Daoud, Shafia Bedier, Sawzan and Abd el-Fatah. (Cairo: The Supreme Council of Antiquities, 2005), 177–82; *id.*, "Saite-Persian Cemetery at Abusir," in *Proceedings of the Ninth International Congress of Egyptologists*, OLA 150, ed. Jean-Claude Goyon and Christine Cardin. (Leuven: Peeters 2006), 129–34.

⁷ The tomb of Udjahorresnet being the very first structure at the site, see its prominent position and a graffito, indicating that the tomb's construction began around 530 BCE, i.e. during the 40th or 41st regnal year of Amasis, see Ladislav Bareš, "Sources from the Saite-Persian Cemetery at Abusir: A Preliminary Evaluation," in *Acts of the Seventh International Conference of Demotic Studies*, ed. Kim Ryholt (The Carsten Niebuhr Institute Publications. Copenhagen: Museum Tusculanum Press, 2002), 36; Ladislav Bareš, "Archaeology," in "Abusir-Spring 2002," Ladislav Bareš, Miroslav Bárta, Květa Smoláriková and Eugen Strouhal, *ZÁS* 130 (2003): 152–53.

⁸ Ladislav Bareš, "Social Status of the Owners of the Large Late Period Shaft Tombs," in *Abusir and Saqqara in the Year 2005. Proceedings of a conference held in Prague (June 27–July 5, 2005)*, ed. Miroslav Bárta, Filip Coppens, Jaromír Krejčí (Prague: Czech Institute of Egyptology, 2006), 1–17.

burial items, can also be easily identified here in later periods (up to the Ptolemaic period)⁹ when the site became less favorable among the elite of Egyptian society, who moved to other places.

The presence of foreign elements within the site of Abusir is uniquely documented by inscriptions written in Aramaic and Phoenician, as well as in the Carian language.¹⁰ Several such inscriptions have already been discovered during excavations of the German Oriental Society (Deutsche Orient-Gesellschaft) between 1902 and 1908 and led by Ludwig Borchardt.

A gravestone made of a yellowish calcite comes from a secondary cemetery of the Late Period, located in the area of the mortuary temple of King Neferirkare and containing the following engraved inscription: "(Belonging) to *Nsnw*, the daughter of Paḥnûm." The dating of the inscription was suggested, by Sachau, as slightly earlier than the 5th century BCE that would be supposed from the script itself.¹¹ B. Porten and A. Yardeni dated the inscription to the 5th century BCE and suggested as another possible reading, "(Belonging) to Nesneu, son of Tapakhnum."¹²

Two further Aramaic inscriptions, these in the form of ostraca written in ink, were uncovered by Borchardt's mission (also further to the north) in the mortuary temple of King Sahure. The content of both inscriptions is identical, despite the fact that the second inscription is only partially preserved. The preserved inscription was dated to

⁹ For the secondary cemeteries, especially the secondary cemetery at the Mastaba of Ptahshepses, see Eugen Strouhal and Ladislav Bareš, with contributions by J. Beneš, D. Březinová, J. Čejka, I. Čejková, B. Hurda, A. Němečková, J. Šilar and Z. Urbanec, *Secondary Cemetery in the Mastaba of Ptahshepses at Abusir* (Prague: Charles University, 1993).

¹⁰ Olivier Masson, *Carian Inscriptions from North Saqqâra and Buhen, Texts from Excavations*, Fifth Memoir, Excavations at North Saqqâra, Documentary Series 3 (London: Egypt Exploration Society, 1978), 91; Frank Kammerzell, *Studien zu Sprache und Geschichte der Karer in Ägypten*, Göttinger Orientforschungen. IV. Reihe: Ägypten, 27 (Wiesbaden: Harrassowitz, 1993), 138–39; Dieter Schürr, "Zur Karischen Inschrift der Stele von Abusir," in *Kadmos* 42 (2003): 91–103.

¹¹ Ludwig Borchardt, *Das Grabdenkmal des Königs Nefer-ir-ke-Re*, Ausgrabungen der Deutschen Orient-Gesellschaft in Abusir 1902–1908, V (Leipzig: Hinrichs'sche Buchhandlung, 1909), 78–79, Abb. 96; Eduard Sachau, *Aramäische Papyrus und Ostraka aus einer jüdischen Militärsiedlung zu Elephantine* (Leipzig: J.C. Hinrichs'sche Buchhandlung, 1911), 87.4, Tafel 74.4.

¹² TAD D.21:1.

2. Unpublished Phoenician and Aramaic Inscriptions from Abusir

2.1 Phoenician inscription from anonymous tomb R3



Fig. 1. Photograph by Květa Smoláriková, Archive of the Czech Institute of Egyptology, Faculty of Arts, Charles University in Prague.

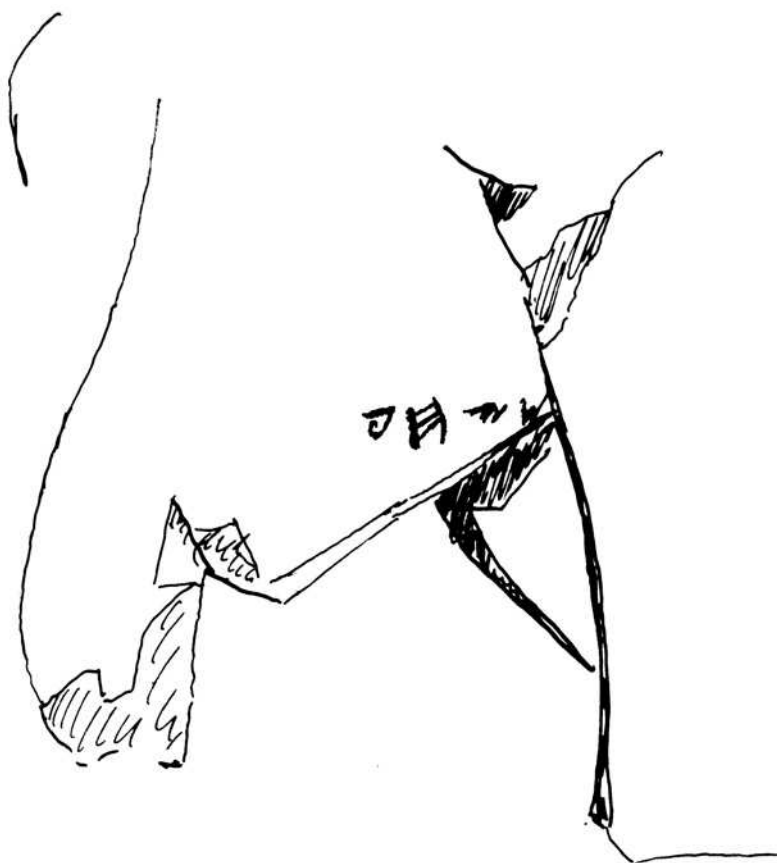


Fig. 2. Drawing by Jan Dušek.

The last sign is unknown and is difficult to decipher. It can perhaps be read as a form of ט; the root טח "to set up(?)" is established in the Aramaic portion of the biblical book of Ezra 4:12, in Aramaic texts from Egypt, and perhaps twice in the Samaria papyri from Wadi Daliyeh.¹⁷ D. Bodi related this root to the Akkadian *ḫiātu(m)* "to supervise", "to inspect", "to check."¹⁸

¹⁷ Aramaic texts from Egypt: TAD C1.1:133 and C3.8IV:7. For the papyri from Wadi Daliyeh: papyrus WDSP 10:7 and WDSP 29, frg. 11:5; Jan Dušek, *Les manuscrits araméens du Wadi Daliyeh et la Samarie vers 450–332 av. J.-C.*, Culture and History of the Ancient Near East 30 (Leiden: Brill, 2007), 241, 245.

¹⁸ Daniel Bodi, "A Biblical Aramaic *Hapax Legomenon* *ḫiātû* (Ezra 4:12) in the Light of Akkadian and Aramaic Texts," *Transeuphratène* 34 (2007): 51–63.

The last sign can be also perhaps interpreted as 𐤏 or 𐤌. The two letters 𐤏𐤌 are attested to on a fragment of a jar discovered in Saqqara.¹⁹ However, we emphasize that identification of the last letter of our inscription, as well as of the root identification, remains very uncertain.

2.2 *Phoenician inscriptions from the tomb of Udjahorresnet*

In 1991, fragments of a jar with two inscriptions²⁰ (denoted “A” and “B”) were discovered in the horizontal corridor leading to the burial chamber in the shaft-tomb of Udjahorresnet, located upon a moderately elevated area in the westernmost part of the Abusir necropolis.²¹ Therefore, on the grounds of its archaeological context, the date has tentatively been assigned as belonging to the early Twenty-Seventh Dynasty. Seven fragments of a large storage vessel²² were identified among other materials, all of them located in the horizontal corridor.²³ Still present are remains of a white calcareous mortar, visible on the surface, streaming down and partially concealing the inscriptions. As has already been noted, the inscriptions were written on two respective fragments of different size; the larger fragment measures 19 × 17 cm and the smaller 8 × 3.7 cm, with a thickness of 0.8 cm.

The two inscriptions were written in ink on the fragment of a storage jar. There is no relationship between the two inscriptions, as they were written by two different hands, probably not at the same time, but in

¹⁹ Judah B. Segal, *Aramaic Texts from North Saqqâra* (London: Egypt Exploration Society, 1983), 144, no. XX, Plate 37:XX.

²⁰ Originally considered by the excavators to be a Demotic inscription and as such its photograph has been published, cf. Miroslav Verner, *Forgotten Pharaohs, Lost Pyramids: Abusir* (Prague: Academia, 1994), 205 infra. Nonetheless, this inaccuracy has been corrected already by Günter Vittmann, *Ägypten und die Fremden im ersten vorchristlichen Jahrtausend*, Kulturgeschichte der Antiken Welt, 97 (Mainz: von Zabern, 2003), 68–69.

²¹ Consult especially Ladislav Bareš with a chapter on pottery by Květa Smoláriková and an appendix by Eugen Strouhal, *The Shaft Tomb of Udjahorresnet at Abusir*, Abusir, IV (Prague: Charles University in Prague, 1999); for the Demotic attestations of Udjahorresnet's name see Ladislav Bareš, “Demotic Attestations of the name ‘Udjahorresnet’ at Abusir,” in *Res Severa Verum Gaudium. Festschrift für Karl-Theodor Zauzich zum 65. Geburtstag am 8. Juni 2004*, *Studia Demotica*, 6, ed. Friedhelm Hoffmann and Heinz-Josef Thissen (Leuven: Peeters, 2004), 33–37.

²² The vessel has been made of light reddish brown clay, well-fired, with a slightly brownish core after firing and light reddish brown slip.

²³ Excavation card 193/H/91 a,b of the Czech Institute of Egyptology, Faculty of Arts, Charles University in Prague; cf. also the Excavation diary 96/91, 131.



Fig. 3. Photograph by Jana Mynářová, Archive of the Czech Institute of Egyptology, Faculty of Arts, Charles University in Prague.

the same period. The *striae* on the surface of the sherd are not regular and the script of both inscriptions approximately follows them.

2.2.1 *Inscription A*

כ א

The letters are larger than those of inscription B. The script is Phoenician non-cursive and nearly erased. Similar inscriptions are authenticated in Saqqara, in Phoenician (some of them non-cursive) and Aramaic script on sherds or ceramic vessels, consisting of two letters and having been interpreted as labels/abbreviations related to the content of the jar or, possibly as potter's marks.²⁴ Two similar inscriptions on jars, one perhaps in Phoenician and the other in Phoenician

²⁴ Noël Aimé-Giron, "Adversaria semitica," *BIFAO* 38 (1939): 1–63, esp. 32, plate III:IV; cf. also p. 63, plate IV:121. Judah B. Segal, *Aramaic Texts from North Saqqâra* (London: Egypt Exploration Society, 1983), 139: no. I; pp. 142–145: no. XI, XV, XIX, XX, XXI, XXV, XXVI; pl. 35–38.



Fig. 4. Drawing by Jan Dušek.

non-cursive script, are also represented in the Clermont-Ganneau collection from Elephantine.²⁵

2.2.2 *Inscription B*

Inscription B is written in Phoenician cursive script from the end of the 6th century BCE.²⁶ It was perhaps deposited in the tomb of Udjahorresnet around the time of his death (517 BCE).

The inscription consists of two lines: the first line seeming to be wholly preserved and the end of the second line missing.

1 מֶשֶׁק לְנָבֹל
2 לְאַשְׁמֵנֶסֶס

²⁵ Hélène Lozachmeur, *La Collection Clermont-Ganneau. Ostraca, épigraphes sur jarre, étiquettes de bois* (Paris: Diffusion De Boccard, 2006), no. 248 (perhaps Phoenician script): vol. 1, 384–85, vol. 2, pl. 258–59; no. 253 (Phoenician non-cursive script): vol. 1, 388–89, vol. 2, pl. 260–61.

²⁶ J. Brian Peckham, *The Development of the Late Phoenician Scripts* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1968), pl. X, pp. 110–111; Johannes Friedrich, Wolfgang Röllig, *Phönizisch-punische Grammatik*, AnOr 55 (Roma: Editrice Pontificio Instituto Biblico, 1999), Schrifttafel V:4–8.

Translation:

mšq for the jar: 9

for Eshmunasoph[]

Commentary:

Line 1. The first line of the inscription consists of two words and of a number.

The number consists of only eight visible vertical bars. The units expressed by the vertical bars are usually grouped in threes. This is the case of the second and third group as well. The first group contains only two bars: the first bar, of what is normally three, was probably erased. For this reason, we reconstruct the number 9. This number is most likely related to the content of the jar (נבל). We must note that the number is not preceded by the indication of the units.

The reading of the first word on the line is clear, but we cannot say the same concerning its meaning. This word is evidenced in several languages and its meaning is often qualified as uncertain.²⁷ The nearest parallel to this word is מִשְׁקֵן in the phrase 25 זִית מִשְׁקֵן and can be found on line 6 of the Phoenician papyrus dated to the 4th–3rd century BCE. It is of unknown provenance and preserved in the Egyptian Museum in Cairo. Its editor, Noël Aimé-Giron, compared it to the phrase זִית מִסִּיק “olives of picking.”²⁸ H. Donner and W. Röllig, who later re-edited the text, qualified the word מִשְׁקֵן as “unklar” (unclear).²⁹

One possibility to understanding the word מִשְׁקֵן may be its potential relationship to the root שָׁקַח “to drink”; the word could be related to some drink or liquid. But the problem with this interpretation is the absence of the units, which should correspond to the number related to it.

²⁷ מִשְׁקֵן in the Punic inscription CIS I 3619,5 can perhaps be a proper noun (María-José Fuentes Estañol, *Vocabulario fenicio* [Barcelona: G. Diamante, 1980], 170.). מִשְׁקֵא with its uncertain meaning is attested to in CIS II 2628,2 and probably also in CIS II 1491,2. The word *mišqu* (*miš-qú*, PRU 3 183: 7) or *mšq* with a meaning “cup” is also attested to in Ugaritic (Gregorio del Olmo Lete and Joaquín Sanmartín, *Diccionario de la Lengua Ugarítica*, Vol. II *m—z*, Aula Orientalis-Supplementa, 8 [Sabadell-Barcelona: Editorial AUSA, 2000], 302; *mi-iš-qú* (*sic!*) in Gregorio del Olmo Lete and Joaquín Sanmartín, translated by Wilfred G.E. Watson, *A Dictionary of the Ugaritic Language in the Alphabetic Tradition*. Part Two: [l–z], HdO 67 [Leiden: Brill, 2003], 593).

²⁸ Noël Aimé-Giron, “Adversaria Semitica,” *BIFAO* 38 (1939): 1–63, esp. 6.

²⁹ KAI 51 (Band II: Kommentar, p. 69). This uncertainty is also expressed by Hoftijzer and Jongeling (*DNWSI*, 705).

These two occurrences of **משקן** and **משק** in the Phoenician inscriptions have a single common denominator: they occur in a context indicating the quantity of a commodity, without specification of its units. In our inscription it most likely concerns the quantity of the commodity in the jar. In KAI 51, it refers to a quantity of olives. In both cases, the word in question is followed by the number without exact units. Thus the words **משק** and **משקן** probably may refer to some kind of standard, measure or unit. The jar with the Phoenician inscription in question would contain nine of these measures. From this standpoint, it compares with the term **מסלת**, interpreted by N. Aimé-Giron as “filling” (“remplissage” in French), appearing equally in the Phoenician inscriptions and followed by a number without further description of units.³⁰

An interesting parallel, perhaps shedding light on the word **משק**, exists in Old Babylonian texts of northern origin: the word *mešēqu*. However, the exact meaning of this term is still under review. It can either refer to “a measuring vessel made of wood,” or “an administrative term, referring to distribution or repayment of barley, but rarely of other commodities.”³¹ The word *mešēqu* is nevertheless often interpreted as well as being a “strickle” or, in other words, a wooden stick that was used for leveling grain in measuring vessels, i.e. to remove the surplus.³² Thus, the first line of our Phoenician inscription might be understood in a way which was kindly suggested to us by Grégoire Chambon: “(after having done the) *mešēqu* for the jar: (remains)

³⁰ Noël Aimé-Giron, “Adversaria semitica,” *BIFAO* 38 (1939): 1–63, esp. 20–27.

³¹ See CAD, M, part II, 38–39; *AHW*, Band II, 648 (“Meßbehälter [für Korn]”). Consult also, Albrecht Goetze, “Thirty Tablets from the Reigns of Abi-ešuh and Ammīditānā,” *JCS* 2 (1948): 85–86.

³² Klaas Roelof Veenhof, “SAG.ĪLLA = SAGGILŪ: ‘Difference Assessed’ on Measuring and Accounting in Some Old Babylonian Texts,” in *Miscellanea Babylonica. Mélanges offertes à Maurice Birot*, ed. Jean-Marie Durand and Jean-Robert Kupper (Paris: Éditions Recherches sur les Civilisations, 1985), 285–306. See also Claus Wilcke, “Nachlese zu A. Poebels Babylonian Legal and Business Documents From the Time of the First Dynasty of Babylon, Chiefly From Nippur (BE 6/2) Teil 1,” *ZA* 73 (1983): 55–56: “*mešēqu* kann aber kaum ein Meßgefäß sein; denn es erscheint in aller Regel, wie in unserem Text, neben einer genormten Maßeinheit. Dabei geben die Texte mitunter an, ob das *mešēqu* dick (*kabrum*), dünn (*raqum*) oder mittel (*birujum*) sei. Den Schlüssel bietet die sumerische Entsprechung (s.o.): es ist das “Glattstreich-Holz” (vgl. šu-ūr = še-e-qu “mit der Hand Glattstreichen”; s. die Belege *AHW*. s.v. *šēqu*). Die Verwendung verschieden starker “Glattstreich-Hölzer” bei genormten Meßgefäßen führt zu verschiedenen Füllmengen in diesen Gefäßen, wenn die Oberkante des Holzes mit dem Gefäßrand abschließt.” And, subsequently, for “strickle,” Marvin A. Powell, “Masse und Gewichte,” in *RIA* 7, p. 494.

9 (measures of grain).” This interpretation is plausible, but remains uncertain because the use of the word *mešēqu*, unfortunately, does not appear to be attested in Babylonian texts of the 1st millennium BCE.

In order to provide a more conclusive answer to the exact meaning of מִשְׁק in the Phoenician inscription, more attestations to the word in Phoenician inscriptions, with more informative contexts, would be needed.

Consistent with the place of discovery of the above-mentioned texts, the authors also considered a possible Demotic loan-word in the Phoenician inscription.³³ However, since the individual fragments might well belong to a torpedo-shaped jar, representing an import, it is not likely that the vessel would have been inscribed in Egypt. Therefore, a Semitic origin of the word *mešēqu* would be more plausible.

Line 2. The second line contains a proper noun with the theophorous element “Eshmun” (Sidonian god of healing), which is well attested in the Phoenician onomastics.³⁴ Some names with this element are well documented in Phoenician inscriptions from Saqqara and Elephantine, which also date to the Persian period.³⁵

Three letters of the second element in the name are preserved and the name seems not to be attested thus far in the Phoenician onomastics.

Only the first letter is clearly preserved: א.

The second letter can be ב or ה. Nevertheless, the reading of ב seems more probable: the script is cursive (see the ב on the first line) and the cursive ה was often different from the non-cursive form in the 6th–5th.³⁶

³³ In the case of a Demotic loan-word, a closest parallel represents the term for a mixed drink (*mṯk*); see Dimitri Meeks, *Année lexicographique*, tome 1, (Paris: Impr. de la Marguerite, 1977), 178, 77.1939.

³⁴ Frank L. Benz, *Personal Names in the Phoenician and Punic Inscriptions: A Catalog, Grammatical Study and Glossary of Elements* (Rome: Biblical Institute Press, 1972), 278–79; Charles R. Krahmalkov, *Phoenician-Punic Dictionary* (Leuven: Peeters, 2000), 82.

³⁵ In Saqqara: אִשְׁמֻנְשֶׁלֶךְ, אִשְׁמֻנְשֶׁמֶשׁ, אִשְׁמֻנְאֵב (Judah B. Segal, *Aramaic Texts from North Saqqāra* (London: Egypt Exploration Society, 1983), 143–44, no. XVIII, 2–4). At Elephantine: Eduard Sachau, *Aramäische Papyrus und Ostraka aus einer jüdischen Militärkolonie zu Elephantine* (Leipzig: J.C. Hinrichs'sche Buchhandlung, 1911), for example, Tafel 69:3.7.

³⁶ J. Brian Peckham, *The Development of the Late Phoenician Scripts* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1968), 110–11, pl. X; Johannes Friedrich and Wolfgang

Only a portion of the head of the third letter is preserved and its interpretation remains uncertain. In the context of the two preceding letters in the second element of the name, it can be reconstructed as פ or ב. The second element of the name can thus be read as אָפּ “to gather” or אָהב “to love”. Ch. R. Krahmalkov mentions one name with the verbal root אָפּ.³⁷ Thus the name can be read *Eshmun-asoph* “Eshmun gathered.” The other possibility would be *Eshmun-ahob* “Eshmun loved.” However, we consider the first possibility to be the more probable.

2.3 Aramaic graffito from the tomb of Nakhtsare

Similarly as in the nearby mortuary complexes of Kings Neferirkare and Sahure (mentioned earlier in the context of discovery of Aramaic inscriptions), Aramaic graffito was also identified in the area of the mastaba of Nakhtsare, located in the vicinity of the pyramid complex of King Raneferef. In this area a secondary cemetery containing burials dated to the Late and Graeco-Roman Period was identified.³⁸ Aramaic graffito, incised into a block of rough limestone, was found in a layer of blown sand and other fragments of limestone, to the east of the entrance to the court of the tomb, 1.5 m below the present surface.³⁹ The graffito is 27 cm long.

The script of the graffito can perhaps be compared to some of the graffiti discovered in various places in Egypt, dating to the first half of the 5th century BCE.⁴⁰ But the closest parallel to the script used in the

Röllig, *Phönizisch-punische Grammatik*, AnOr 55 (Roma: Editrice Pontificio Instituto Biblico, 1999), Schrifttafel V:4–8.

³⁷ Charles R. Krahmalkov, *Phoenician-Punic Dictionary* (Leuven: Peeters, 2000), 66.

³⁸ For the secondary cemetery, consult Jaromír Krejčí, Vivienne G. Callender, and Miroslav Verner, with contributions by Viktor Černý, Martina Kujanová, Eugen Strouhal and Hana Vymazalová, *Abusir XII. Minor Tombs in the Royal Necropolis I (The Mastabas of Nebtyemneferes and Nakhtsare, Pyramid Complex Lepsius no. 24 and Tomb Complex Lepsius no. 25)* (Prague: Czech Institute of Egyptology, Faculty of Arts, Charles University in Prague, 2008), 48–51.

³⁹ Jaromír Krejčí, Vivienne G. Callender, Miroslav Verner, with contributions by Viktor Černý, Martina Kujanová, Eugen Strouhal and Hana Vymazalová, *Abusir XII. Minor Tombs in the Royal Necropolis I (The Mastabas of Nebtyemneferes and Nakhtsare, Pyramid Complex Lepsius no. 24 and Tomb Complex Lepsius no. 25)* (Prague: Czech Institute of Egyptology, Faculty of Arts, Charles University in Prague, 2008), 64.

⁴⁰ TAD D22:1–54.

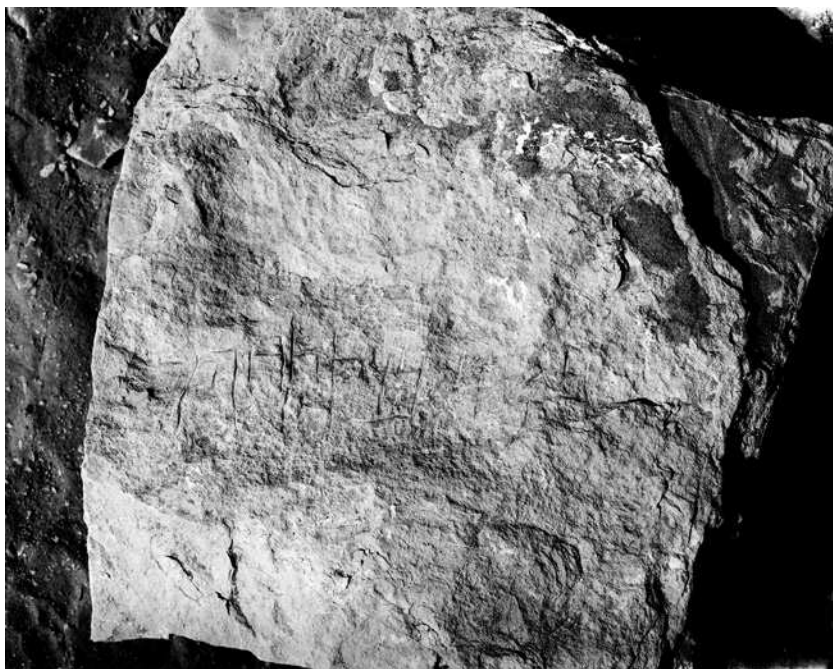


Fig. 5. Photograph by Milan Zemina, Archive of the Czech Institute of Egyptology, Faculty of Arts, Charles University in Prague.

graffito is represented by four incised and painted inscriptions on the ceramic sarcophagi discovered by Gustave Jéquier in the necropolis of South Saqqara from the Persian-Ptolemaic period.⁴¹ Noël Aimé-Giron dated these sarcophagi to the late 5th–early 4th century BCE.⁴² B. Porten and A. Yardeni indicate a rather larger time span, between 7th and 3rd century BCE, for the whole group of sarcophagi from South Saqqara.⁴³ However, in the case of the graffito from the tomb of Nakhtsare, we lean toward approximately the 5th–4th century BCE.

⁴¹ Gustave Jéquier, *Fouilles à Saqqarah. Deux pyramides du Moyen Empire* (Le Caire: Service des Antiquités de l'Égypte—Institut Français d'Archéologie Orientale du Caire, 1933), 49–52, Pl. XI. Noël Aimé-Giron, *Textes araméens d'Égypte* (Le Caire: Service des Antiquités de l'Égypte—Institut Français d'Archéologie Orientale, 1931), 95–96; no. 97 *a-b*, Pl. XIII; 100–01; no. 100 *a-b*, Pl. XIV. TAD D18.6 and D18.10.

⁴² Noël Aimé-Giron, *Textes araméens d'Égypte*, 97.

⁴³ TAD D, p. 238.



Fig. 6. Drawing by Jan Dušek.

(○) ביסן ברת תחות

Bysn, daughter of *T3-(n.t)-ḥw.t*

The inscription contains the proper name *Bysn* and the name of her mother. The name of the mother is Egyptian: *T3-(n.t)-ḥw.t* “belonging (f.) to the temple.”⁴⁴

Some sign is possibly written at the end of the inscription. It could be either a *waw* or an accidental line in the stone. It is not certain if it is really a letter belonging to the name of the mother.

2.4 *An Aramaic inscription on a limestone block, said to originate from the mortuary temple of Neferirkare*

A photograph of the inscription was published in 1994 by Miroslav Verner, identifying the mortuary temple of King Neferirkare as the place of its discovery and referring to Borchardt’s excavations at the site.⁴⁵ B. Porten and A. Yardeni published its drawing and transcription and proposed its date to the first half of the 5th century BCE, with an interrogation point.⁴⁶ This dating, even if uncertain, is possible.

⁴⁴ A similar name, תחות is attested in other three Aramaic texts from Egypt: TAD B3.9:3, B8.4:20, C3.26:5. See Walter Kornfeld, *Onomastica Aramaica aus Ägypten*, Österreichische Akademie der Wissenschaften, Philosophisch-Historische Klasse, Sitzungsberichte 333 (Wien: Verlag der Österreichischen Akademie der Wissenschaften, 1978), 95.

⁴⁵ Miroslav Verner, *Forgotten Pharaohs, Lost Pyramids: Abusir* (Praha: Academia, 1994), 93 *infra*.

⁴⁶ TAD D22.2.



Fig. 7. Photograph by Milan Zemina, Archive of the Czech Institute of Egyptology, Faculty of Arts, Charles University in Prague.

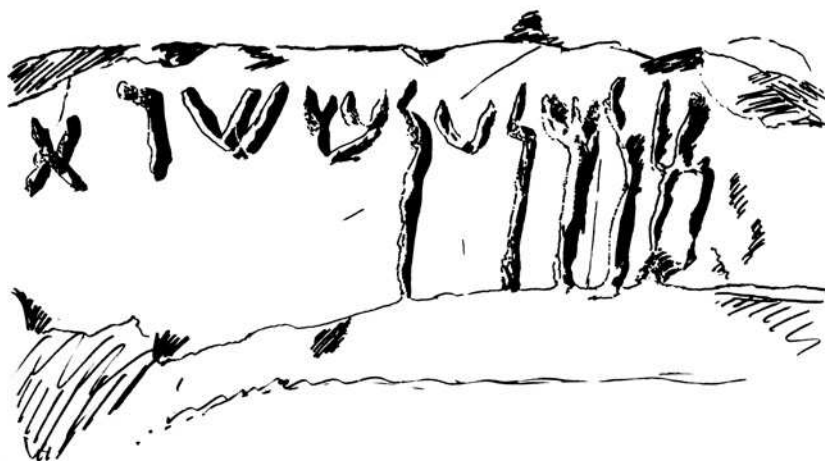


Fig. 8. Drawing Jan Dušek.

מנכנען בר שוא

Mannu-ki-na'an son of Šewa'

The proper noun seems to be new. The first element *mannu-ki* “who is like” is documented in the Neo-Assyrian and Neo-Babylonian onomastics.⁴⁷ It also appears in Aramaic texts from Egypt.⁴⁸ The element *na'an* is, however, as yet unknown. The patronymic שוא “equal” is Semitic and is attested in the Aramaic texts from Egypt.⁴⁹

⁴⁷ Heather D. Baker, ed., *The Prosopography of the Neo-Assyrian Empire*. vol. 2, Part II: L-N (Helsinki: The Neo-Assyrian Text Corpus Project, 2001), 680-99; Heather D. Baker, “/corrigenda to fascicles 1/I–3/I (1998–2002), Names beginning with M,” <http://homepage.univie.ac.at/heather.baker/pnaupdatemnames.html>. Knut L. Tallqvist, *Neubabylonisches Namenbuch zu den Geschäftsurkunden aus der Zeit des Šamašumukin bis Xerxes*, Acta societatis Scientiarum fennicae, 32.2 (Leipzig: August Preis, 1902), 99.

⁴⁸ KWIC, 372.

⁴⁹ TAD A3.6:1; A3.9:1.9; C4.6:15. Walter Kornfeld, *Onomastica aramaica aus Ägypten* (Wien: Verlag der österreichischen Akademie der Wissenschaften, 1978), 72.